



Is this it?: Novak Djokovic hinted he may have played his last French Open this year. GETTY IMAGES

five matches. The immensely talented but relatively light-hitting Italian earned a bronze medal at the Paris Olympics on these courts and had racked up a career-best 19-3 record on the European clay court circuit, reaching the final at Monte Carlo and semis at Madrid and Rome.

"Alcaraz has such an MPH advantage in every stroke," all-time great and *Tennis Channel* analyst Martina Navratilova said. "On clay, a [backhand] one-hander has so much trouble against Alcaraz's power." As the inspired Italian easily held serve for 5-4, Jim Courier, the former No. 1 and *TNT Sports* analyst, said, "Musetti (**right**) can thump backhands and find angles with it. He has the best one-handed backhand now." Looking rattled, Alcaraz erred on three forehands — his signature weapon — and

dropped the first set 6-4.

The momentum switched in the second set tie-break when Alcaraz pummelled and broke down Musetti's vulnerable backhand to take it 7-3. After the Spanish maestro held serve at love to go ahead 1-0 in the third set and whacked a forehand

winner to start the next game, *TNT* guest analyst Andre Agassi said, "Vamos Man is finding the range. He's hitting the ball harder and earlier." Indeed, he was, and like a battered boxer, Musetti couldn't take much more punishment. Suffering from a painful hamstring injury, he lost 23 of the last 30 points and threw in the towel. The final score: 4-6, 7-6 (3), 6-0, 2-0 retired.

The other and more intriguing semifinal featured the best player in history against the best player now. Could Djokovic defy Father Time one more time against Sinner, a player with a strikingly similar game but 15 years younger?

Nerves of steel

Despite playing only his third tournament of the year due to a three-month drug suspension, Sinner had shown no signs of rust, except perhaps in shot selection during his 7-6 (5), 6-1 loss to Alcaraz in the Rome final three weeks earlier. The Sinner-Djokovic rivalry was



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